

and then sending to a new husband again," says Dinesh Soni, coordinator of Prayas, an organisation active in Bhilwara. This nata ceremony involves expenditure, on feasting among other things. A widow gets only minimal bride price, and often none. At times, what she gets from the second husband is passed on to the family of her late husband.

Some child widows are hit harder than others. Bachhi Bhil, 16, of Aanwa village in Tonk district, got married at 11 and lost her husband Mauji Ram of Soran village to snakebite last year. She works with her father Durga Bhil in his fields. "She can live on with me, I am in no hurry to send her," he says. Others are so broken that they cannot think of remarriage. Meera Mali, 18, daughter of

labourer Jagdish Mali in Duni village, and married at seven in Cheetar village in Ajmer, lost her husband four years ago when a stone quarry he worked in caved in. She has taken it so hard that her family is more concerned about her health than finding a match for her.

And then are the teenage mothers, widows at the very stepping stone to life with the responsibility of bringing up a child or two. Manphool Dhakar of Bisania village became a mother at 16, having married Parasaram when she was five. When Manphool's son turned one, her husband, a labourer, died of cardiac arrest. Now 22, Manphool faces taunts when she wears bright clothes, or ornaments. She cannot wed again; that would mean leaving her son with her in-laws, or her



BACHHI, 16
Married at 11, widowed at 15,
Aanwa village, Tonk

"I am asked to stay aloof. I wonder why I am not allowed to ride the swings on Teej like other girls." SHANTI, 10, PANDER VILLAGE, BHILWARA

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

SUMAN, 8

Married at 4, widowed at 5,
Pander village, Bhilwara

